



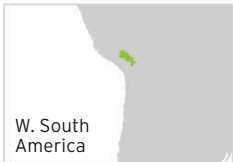
Caño Cristales

Colorful aquatic plants and clear water combine to create a liquid rainbow

On the Serrania de la Macarena tableland in central Colombia runs a 60-mile- (100-km-) long river that for five months of the year turns a combination of red, green, yellow, and blue. The Caño Cristales’ colorful display is due to the blooming of an endemic plant called *Macarenia clavigera*, which requires a precise combination of water and sunlight levels to take on its bright red hues. Other green plants, the sandy riverbed, and the clear water reflecting the sky provide the other colors. Despite being rich in aquatic plants, the river is thought to contain no fish.

△ CRYSTAL CLEAR WATERS

The Caño Cristales is a relatively fast-flowing river with waterfalls, rapids, and deep, swirling pools. The water lacks sediment and nutrients, and as a result is extremely clear.

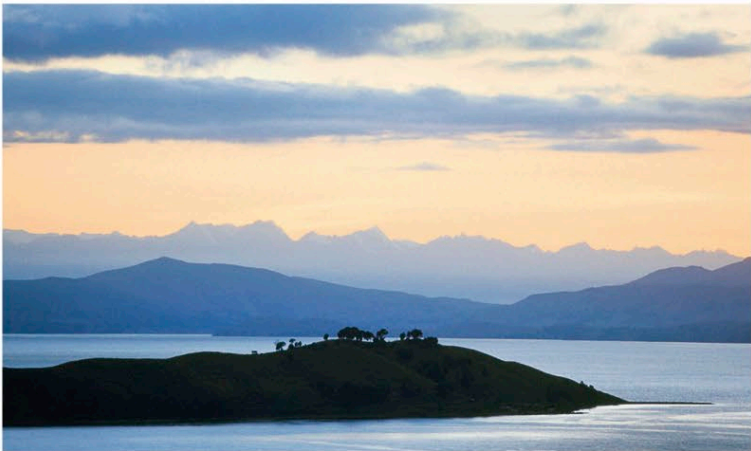


Lake Titicaca

The world’s highest navigable lake, and South America’s largest

The largest freshwater lake in South America, Lake Titicaca covers 3,230 square miles (8,370 square km), straddling the border between Peru and Bolivia. It is situated in the Altiplano basin (see p.96), high in the Andes, and at 12,507 ft (3,812 m) above sea level is the world’s highest commercially navigable lake.

The lake’s two sub-basins are connected by the Strait of Tiquina. The larger section to the north, Lago Grande, is much deeper than the smaller Wiñaymarka. More than 25 rivers from five major systems drain into the lake, but it has just one outflow, the Desaguadero River, at its southern end. The river accounts for only about 5 percent of Lake Titicaca’s water loss; the rest is lost by evaporation in its arid, windy environment.



◁ FALLING LEVELS

In the last few years, the water level of Lake Titicaca has been slowly falling. Lack of rainfall has been compounded by reduced levels of summer meltwater as glaciers shrink due to climate change.

ALTIPLANO LAKES

This cross-section of the northern and central drainage basins of the Altiplano shows the current levels of Lake Titicaca and Lake Poopó alongside levels of ancient lakes that have dried up, leaving salt flats behind. By the end of 2015, Lake Poopó had also completely dried up, partly due to low levels of water in Lake Titicaca, which ultimately feeds it.

